

Israeli strike on Gaza church draws swift condemnation



OMAR AL-QATTAA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A delegation of top Christian clerics visits Holy Family Church, the only Catholic church in Gaza, on Friday, a day after it was hit in an Israeli strike, killing three people and causing extensive damage. The Israel Defense Forces said an initial inquiry “suggests that fragments from a shell ... hit the church mistakenly.”

Mission creep at antisemitism unit, critics allege

This article is by Laura Meckler, Dan Rosenzweig-Ziff, Susan Surluga, Perry Stein and Emily Davies

In 2021, future vice president JD Vance delivered a speech titled “The Universities Are the Enemy.” A few years later, during his campaign, Donald Trump called college leaders “Marxist maniacs.” Now their administration is using the full force of the federal

government to investigate long-standing conservative complaints about universities, making sweeping demands and cutting billions of dollars in federal funding as it works to bring campuses to heel. The most powerful vehicle for the onslaught has been the Joint Task Force to Combat Anti-Semitism. The administration established the task force in February

to counter what it describes as widespread failure by universities to protect Jewish students since the start of campus protests against the Israel-Gaza war. In reality, many of the task force’s unprecedented demands and punishments have nothing to do with antisemitism. Instead, they seek hiring and programming changes to strip long-standing conservative targets including DEI and a liberal worldview from

higher education. A White House official, who was not authorized to speak publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity, said the task force began by focusing on antisemitism but described antisemitism as only “the symptom” of a broken and corrupt culture on college SEE TASK FORCE ON A4 Another GMU probe: DOJ opens an investigation into hiring. B13

Deportees traded for 10 Americans held by Caracas

3-NATION DEAL SENDS VENEZUELAN HOME Trump had put 250 migrants in Salvadoran prison

BY KAREN DEYOUNG AND SAMANTHA SCHMIDT

More than 250 Venezuelans deported in March by the Trump administration and flown to a high-security prison in El Salvador were sent home Friday in exchange for 10 American citizens and permanent U.S. residents imprisoned in Venezuela by the government of President Nicolás Maduro. The swap at least partially ended one of the most controversial episodes of President Donald Trump’s second term — the secret removal under a 1798 wartime law and indefinite incarceration without charge of Venezuelan mi-

grants he said were members of a “terrorist” gang. Legal challenges to those actions continue. In a carefully coordinated series of events following months of negotiations among Washington, Caracas and San Salvador, the 252 Venezuelans were bused from El Salvador’s Terrorism Confinement Center (CECOT) to be picked up by two aircraft sent from Venezuela. Simultaneously, a U.S.-chartered Gulfstream plane departed a small Georgia airport carrying U.S. diplomatic officials and medical personnel en route to SEE VENEZUELA ON A12 Americans released: Windsurfer, Navy sailor among the freed. A12

Bondi asks court to unseal Epstein records

Uncertain if judge will agree to release grand jury transcripts

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK AND MARK BERMAN

The Justice Department on Friday asked a federal court to release grand jury transcripts connected to deceased financier Jeffrey Epstein, responding to a growing political outcry over the agency’s unfulfilled promise to release more details on the government’s investigation of his alleged sex-trafficking of minors.

Officials cited the “extensive public interest” in seeking to make public sealed material from the years-long investigation into Epstein, who was indicted in 2019 on sex-trafficking charges, and his associate Ghislaine Maxwell, who was convicted of sex-trafficking charges in 2021. The Justice Department’s filings, which were signed by Attorney General Pam Bondi and Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche, made clear that it may take some time before any transcripts are released, if at all. A judge would have to agree to release them, a process that could take weeks or months. Even then, their disclosure is by no means SEE EPSTEIN ON A6

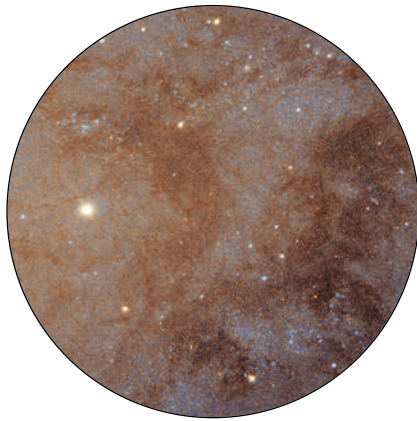
One Iranian nuclear site destroyed, U.S. assesses

Fordow shows clearest damage; 2 other facilities remain under review

BY ALEX HORTON AND WARREN P. STROBEL

The United States has assessed that only one of Iran’s three principal nuclear facilities was destroyed in U.S. strikes last month, officials and people familiar with ongoing assessments said, prompting renewed questions about President Donald Trump’s claim that Tehran’s nuclear program was “totally obliterated.” Of the three facilities targeted in a massive nighttime bombing operation, the Fordow site is the one where the damage has been clearest, according to U.S. officials and a congressional aide familiar with briefings provided to lawmakers. Air Force B-2 stealth bombers dropped 12 huge ground-penetrating bombs through ventilation shafts into the underground facility. There are ongoing analyses of the damage at the other sites, Natanz and Isfahan, but the current indication is they were not dealt a knockout blow, according to a U.S. official familiar with the intelligence assessments. “We definitely can’t say it was obliterated,” the official said of

Iran’s nuclear program. Like others in this report, the official and the congressional aide spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive and ongoing assessments. The objective to collapse the deeply buried infrastructure at Fordow “seems to have succeeded,” the aide said. Adding to the confidence, they said, was an intimate understanding of the facility by U.S. war planners, who had developed the 30,000-pound bunker-buster bombs specifically in response to the Iranian effort to burrow the site into a mountain. Fordow is one of two main sites in Iran where thousands of fast-spinning centrifuges were installed to purify uranium. But there are still significant unknowns, including whether the centrifuges at the deepest levels of Fordow were destroyed or rendered inoperable, or if they were moved before the bombing. If they were not present, “then they are back in business,” the aide said of the Iranians. “That is the key component to enriching the material.” Much less is known about the efficacy of the strikes at the two other facilities, the aide said. The bunker-busting bombs were not used at the Isfahan site because the Pentagon had assessed that it was “pretty much impenetrable,” the aide said. Isfahan, the country’s largest nuclear SEE IRAN ON A6



The Hubble telescope zoomed in on the galaxy next door. It’s mind-boggling.

BY JOEL ACHENBACH, SHIKHA SUBRAMANIAM AND AADIT TAMBE

The Andromeda galaxy is the galaxy next door, a very faint, fuzzy thing in the night sky, larger than a full moon. Textbooks claim it’s visible to the naked eye. Most of us have never noticed it. Too many city lights. Now, thanks to a decade of observations by the Hubble Space Telescope, we have a chance to see Andromeda as never before. Early this year, NASA released a stunning mosaic that provides the sharpest and most detailed view of the great spiral galaxy. “It’s phenomenal that human beings,

who have looked at Andromeda from time immemorial, are suddenly able to see this much detail. It’s a gift,” said Jennifer Wiseman, a NASA astrophysicist and the senior project scientist for the Hubble mission. “We need to take a moment to be awestruck. Because it’s beautiful.” Andromeda, Wiseman said, is “our fraternal twin,” a spiral galaxy like the one we live in, the Milky Way. When we look at Andromeda — 2.5 million light-years away from Earth — it’s like looking in the mirror.

SEE ANDROMEDA ON A11

NASA, ESA, J. DALCANTON (UNIVERSITY OF WASHINGTON), B. F. WILLIAMS (UNIVERSITY OF WASHINGTON), L. C. JOHNSON (UNIVERSITY OF WASHINGTON), THE PHAT TEAM AND R. GENDLER/HUBBLE TELESCOPE

Allies’ advice on talking to Trump gives Kyiv a win

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, SIOBHÁN O’GRADY, ELLEN FRANCIS AND CATHERINE BELTON

When Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky got off the phone with President Donald Trump on Independence Day, his top aide could scarcely contain his relief. “Wow, that was the best call with him we ever had,” his chief of staff, Andriy Yermak, said after Zelensky hung up — and Zelensky agreed, according to a Ukrainian official who, like others interviewed for this article, spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe sensitive internal discussions. The call felt so positive from Ukraine’s perspective that it caught Zelensky’s staff by surprise, the official said. “The spirit was uplifted, but it is too early to celebrate,” the official said. “We have to wait for actions.” The Ukrainians know better than most how much fortunes can shift with Trump’s mercurial moods. In February, Zelensky and Trump engaged in an Oval Office SEE ZELENSKY ON A8 European Union: Bloc hits Russia with sanctions targeting energy. A8

IN THE NEWS

Ankle bracelet for Jair Bolsonaro New restrictions on the former president signal that Brazil has no intention of backing off his prosecution amid White House pressure. A5
Tesla goes to court The carmaker has largely avoided trial by settling lawsuits, but now it faces a defect-related case in Miami. A18

THE NATION **Ex-aides** are invoking the Fifth Amendment as a probe into the Biden White House widens. A3
The DOJ asked California sheriffs to provide the names and records of jailed noncitizens. A3

THE WORLD **Taiwan** held expanded drills to show China, and Trump, it’s ready to defend itself. A7
In Haiti, police and museum staff rescued precious artwork as violent gangs neared. A9

THE ECONOMY **Kevin Hassett’s** potential nomination as chair of the Federal Reserve is raising questions about whether the next leader will be independent. A14
Scam centers linked to China are targeting Americans, with benefits for Beijing, a new report warned. A18

STYLE **CBS’s decision** to end Stephen Colbert’s “Late Show” may have implications beyond late-night television. B1
SPORTS **Paying Terry McLaurin** big money would be the right thing to do — and bad business, Neil Greenberg writes. B7

THE REGION **Glenn Youngkin** regaled an Iowa Republican crowd with the story of how he became governor of Virginia. B13
A Senate panel advanced the FBI’s request to pay for its D.C. relocation with money that had been set aside for a Maryland campus. B13

BUSINESS NEWS.....	A13
COMICS.....	B4
OBITUARIES.....	B15
OPINION PAGES.....	A15
TELEVISION.....	B6
WORLD NEWS.....	A7